Project Management Plan

Introduction

Modern colleges and universities rely on many software applications and digital services to support higher education. These products often serve a variety of purposes from research, to administration, to e-learning and instruction. At a large state college institution, these applications can be found in nearly every department, from administration, to academic spaces, to campus facilities. Without a centralized system for tracking the type of software, licensing agreements, and usage of these applications, the institution risks mismanaging their budget, becoming vulnerable to cybersecurity incidents, and experiencing unexpected lapses in service when licensing expires. To address this, a dedicated Information Technology (IT) Department has initiated a project team to develop a software tracking database that will list and manage all software related assets for such an institution. As the manager of this project, I will outline an implementation plan for the proposed database to be created using the six project management phases described in Baars' *Project Management Handbook* (2006).

Initiation

In the initiation phase, the problem has been identified as a lack of a centralized system to track software and digital assets for the institution. This includes records of purchases, licensing agreements, installation and utilization on institutional devices. The Director of Information Technology will serve as the project sponsor. Stakeholders for the project include IT staff members, department leads, administration, and those who oversee compliance. The primary goal of the project is to design a centralized, accurate, and secure database to manage the

institution's digital assets. A brief outline of the project's scope, cost, and any risks or resources consumed will be developed and submitted to respective department leaders for approval.

Definition

During the definition phase, the detailed scope of the project will be established. Functional requirements of the database include the ability to record software name, developer, version, license type, acquisition dates, assigned departments, and any distribution limits. Roles and responsibilities will be formally assigned, with myself, the project manager, overseeing progress, a database analyst designing the database's infrastructure, and IT staff assisting with gathering and validating the information to be submitted in the database. Deliverables for this phase include a requirements document along with a detailed project timeline. Potential challenges might include facilitating cooperation between departments and correcting any inaccuracies in existing software records prior to entering them into the new database.

Design

For the design phase, the technical structure of the database will be developed. This will be done by creating entity-relationship diagrams to outline tables, fields, and relationships between objects in the database. The database administrator will work closely with the IT team to determine the best database platform to host on while considering compatibility with existing systems. From there, user roles and permissions will be granted to any additional systems administrators, IT technicians, or read-only privileges for necessary departmental users. Access levels will be guarded to ensure data integrity, and authentication measures will be implemented to strengthen data security. Secure backups will also be created to prevent data loss. The

proposed design will then be reviewed with the Director of IT for approval. Deliverables in this phase include a finalized system design with technical specifications.

Development

During the development phase, the database will be constructed according to the approved design. The database analyst will work with a database developer to build and configure the system under the supervision of myself, the project manager. A structured testing strategy will be developed, using system testing and a pilot test in a selected academic department to identify any errors or usability issues. IT staff and selected end users will participate in testing to ensure the system meets operational needs. Technical manuals and user training materials will be developed and distributed with the results of the pilot test. Afterwards, user feedback will be collected and training materials updated as necessary. Deliverables for this phase will be a working prototype of the database, completed test results, and eventually finalized training documentation for users.

Implementation

In the implementation phase, the database will be deployed in stages across the institution. With the deployment of the new database, authorized users will also receive the training documentation. Feedback will be collected and any necessary adjustments will be made before the full campus-wide deployment. The full rollout will follow a schedule to minimize disruption to academic and administrative operations. Training sessions will be conducted for IT staff and related positions to ensure proper data entry, system maintenance, and responsiveness to troubleshooting requests. Ongoing technical support will be provided during the transition

period. Deliverables of this phase will include a fully operational database and completed training materials for all relevant users.

Follow-up

In the follow-up (also known as “maintenance”) phase, responsibility for the database will transition fully to the IT department for ongoing system oversight. Regular system checks will be conducted to ensure the database’s integrity, functionality, and compliance. Scheduled updates will address software changes, any new licensing agreements, and new needs the institution might have in the future. A formal report after implementation will document what was learned during the span of the project, as well as recommendations for future improvements.

Conclusion

This proposed project to develop a centralized software tracking database is very important for ensuring efficiency, security, and operability for the higher education institution. As the acting project manager, by following the six project management phases outlined by Baars, this implementation plan will provide a structured approach to navigating the project from start to finish (2006). Each phase has its distinct responsibilities, deliverables, and methods to support a successful project completion. The proposed database project will provide long-term usefulness by improving oversight of the institution’s software assets. This will help to better serve the people at the institution.

References

Baars, W. (2006). *Project management handbook* (Version 1.1). DANS, Data Archiving and Networked Services.